

INTERVAL QUALITY SYSTEM

How intervals are classified by quality, how quality changes, and the symmetry of interval inversions.

QUALITY PROGRESSIONS

Major / Minor Intervals (2nds, 3rds, 6ths, 7ths)

dim
DIMINISHED

min
MINOR

MAJ
MAJOR

aug
AUGMENTED

lower 1 semitone lower 1 semitone raise 1 semitone raise 1 semitone

Major is the baseline. Lower by one half-step → Minor. Lower again → Diminished. Raise from Major by one half-step → Augmented.

Perfect Intervals (4ths, 5ths, Unison, Octave)

dim
DIMINISHED

PERF
PERFECT

aug
AUGMENTED

Perfect intervals skip the Major/Minor distinction entirely. Perfect is the baseline. No "major" or "minor" — only Perfect, Diminished, or Augmented.

P4 raised = Aug4 = Tritone. This is the dividing line between the two systems.

THE INVERSION RULE

Original +
Inversion = 9

Flip any interval upside down — the two numbers always add up to 9. The quality flips too (except Perfect).

2 ↔ 7
SUM = 9

3 ↔ 6
SUM = 9

4 ↔ 5
SUM = 9

1 ↔ 8
SUM = 9

Major
↓
Minor
QUALITY INVERTS

Aug
↓
Dim
QUALITY INVERTS

Perfect
↓
Perfect
STAYS PERFECT

WORKED EXAMPLES

M3 (C → E)
invert ↓
m6 (E → C)
3 + 6 = 9 · Major → Minor

m2 (C → D_b)
invert ↓
M7 (D_b → C)
2 + 7 = 9 · Minor → Major

P5 (C → G)
invert ↓
P4 (G → C)
5 + 4 = 9 · Perfect → Perfect

WHY "PERFECT"? — THE OVERTONE SERIES

Perfect intervals (P4, P5, P8) appear very early in the natural overtone series — the physical overtones that ring when any note is played. They sound maximally open and stable because they ARE the building blocks of sound itself. Power chords in rock use only P5 + P8 because there's no 3rd to define major or minor — just pure, culturally universal power. The "Perfect" name reflects their privileged acoustic status.